

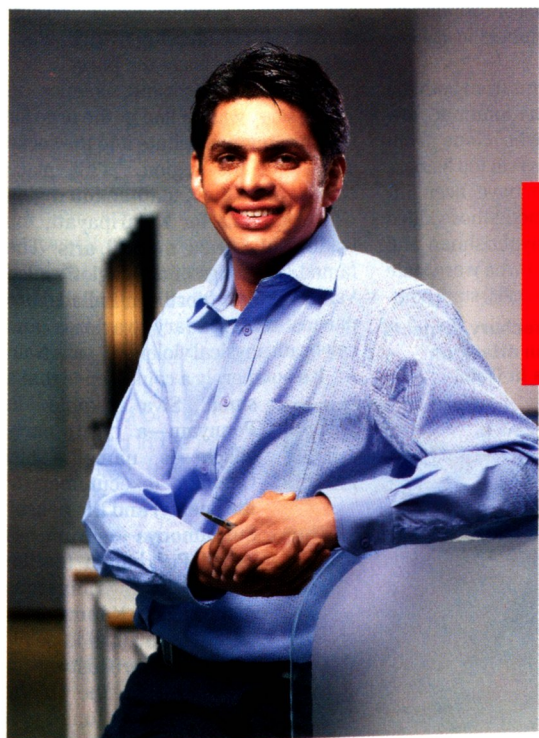


demanding deployment of Central forces in the district, while Opposition leader Oommen Chandy observed a day's fast in Kannur to protest against the violence. Ramesh Chennithala, president of the Kerala Pradesh Congress Committee, echoed the demands of the BJP leaders and called for the urgent intervention of Central police forces to bring peace. "The state

Government and its police have failed miserably. The Government does not allow the free function of police force. Home Minister Koderi Balakrishnan, who hails from Thalassery, should resign immediately," says Chennithala.

Though Thalassery has been notorious for political murders since 1970s, there is a surge whenever CPI(M) comes to power. "The police become completely partisan and let the cadres run riot. It is state-sponsored terrorism," says BJP leader P.S. Sreedharan Pillai. However, CPI(M) counters this allegation and puts the blame squarely on BJP. "The BJP and RSS always strike whenever we are in power because they know we will be defensive. We won't put our own government in difficulty," says C. Rajeevan, a local leader of CPI(M). The recent killings have forced Chief Minister V.S. Achuthanandan to make an appeal to all, cutting across party lines: "Let us not take life in the name of politics. My appeal is to my party workers too."

Following the recent spurt in violence, more than 1,000 police personnel have been deployed in the district and 198 CPI(M) and 139 BJP-RSS



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